

Backyard Grilling Intensive: Student Handout

Jake's Table | Grilling Intensive Track | Pop-Up Season

This handout covers the core skills from today's class. Take it home and use it as a reference at your own grill. The goal is confidence - knowing your fire, reading your food, and finishing with flavor.

Fire Setup

Two-Zone Charcoal Fire

- Use a chimney starter - no lighter fluid. Fill the chimney, light the bottom with newspaper, wait 15 minutes until the top coals are ashed over and glowing orange.
- Pour lit coals onto one side of the kettle. This is your direct (sear) zone.
- Leave the other half empty. This is your indirect (finish) zone.
- Replace the grate, brush clean with a grill brush, then wipe with an oil-soaked paper towel using long tongs.
- Let the grate heat 5 minutes before placing food.

Temperature Check

- Hold your palm 5 inches above the grate: 2 seconds = high heat, 4 seconds = medium, 6 seconds = medium-low.
 - Invest in an instant-read thermometer. Guessing doneness by feel takes years of practice - temperature is reliable from day one.
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Proteins: Guidelines by Type

Protein	Zone Start	Internal Temp Target	Rest Time	Notes
Ribeye (1.25")	Direct sear 2 min/side	130°F (med-rare)	7-8 min	Finish indirect
Chicken thighs	Direct 4 min/side	175°F	5 min	High temp = juicy thighs
Pork chops (1")	Direct 3 min/side	145°F	5 min	Brine overnight for best results
Salmon fillet	Direct skin-down 4 min	125°F center	3 min	Oil grate heavily
Portobello cap	Direct 4 min/side	Tender when pressed	2 min	Marinate 30 min before
Corn in husk	Direct, rotate often	Until husks char	None	Peel and butter at table

Troubleshooting

Flare-Ups

Caused by fat dripping onto hot coals. Move food to the indirect zone immediately - do not spray with water, which scatters ash and drops the fire temperature unevenly. Let the flare-up die, then return the food to direct heat for the final sear.

Food Sticking to the Grate

Usually caused by an insufficiently oiled or heated grate, or by moving food before a crust has formed. If the food resists when you try to flip it, wait 30 more seconds - it will release cleanly when a proper sear has developed. Never force a flip.

Uneven Cooking

Caused by an uneven fire or inconsistent protein thickness. Pound chicken thighs to even thickness before grilling. Rotate food 90 degrees halfway through each side for even grill marks and consistent heat exposure. On gas grills, check for hot spots by laying bread across the grate and seeing which slices toast fastest.

Underseasoned Food

Season more boldly than feels right. High heat burns off a portion of surface salt. Salt at least 30 minutes before grilling for steaks (longer is better); for chicken, season the night before or use a brine. Taste before plating - compound butters and finishing sauces can rescue mild seasoning at the end.

Sauce Recipes

Chimichurri

- 1 cup flat-leaf parsley, packed
- ¼ cup fresh oregano
- 3 cloves garlic
- 2 tbsp red wine vinegar
- ¼ tsp red pepper flakes
- ½ cup olive oil, salt to taste
- Blend in a food processor until coarsely chopped but not smooth. Rest 30 minutes before serving.

Garden Herb Compound Butter

- 4 tbsp room-temp unsalted butter
 - 1 tbsp thyme, 1 tbsp rosemary (both minced)
 - 1 garlic clove, grated - zest of ½ lemon
 - Roll in parchment, refrigerate until firm. Slice and place on hot food at service.
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Five Rules to Remember

- Salt early and generously - 30 minutes minimum, overnight for thick cuts.
- Two-zone fire: always have an escape from the flames.
- Thermometer over touch - accuracy beats guesswork every time.
- Rest your protein - cutting too soon loses all the juice.
- Season the grate, not just the food - a clean, oiled grate changes everything.